

# THE CONSENT GAP

Governments are quietly stitching the separate records they hold on you — health, tax, justice, benefits, census — into **one combined file**. It's legal. It's spreading worldwide.

**Nobody asked you.**

**56,000,000**

census records linked to tax & benefits data in **one** UK project (96.7%)

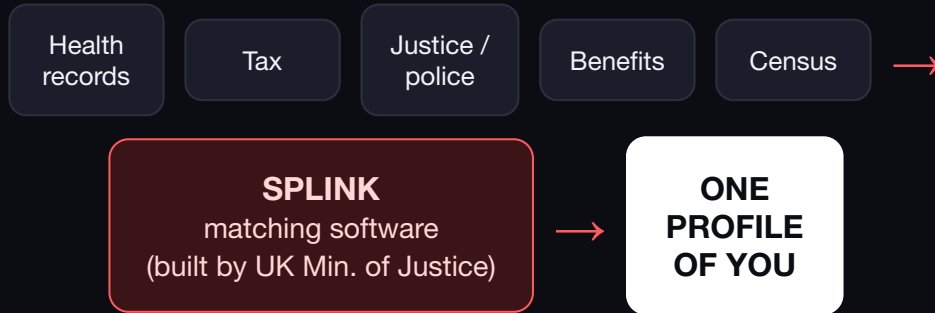
**8 + 2**

countries with confirmed govt use, plus the **EU** & the **UN** — only who admitted it

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consent · notice · opt-out

## HOW IT WORKS



Records that used to sit apart, with no shared ID, are matched into a single linked identity — across government departments, without your knowledge.

### The shift that matters most

It started as **counting populations** (statistics). It's becoming **identifying named individuals** — in real time. That's the line, and it's already been crossed.

## UNITED KINGDOM — THE DEEPEST USER (NATIONAL + LOCAL)

**National:** Office for National Statistics (census, tax, benefits) · NHS England (patient records) · Ministry of Justice (courts, prisons, probation + real-time court use + police arrest lookups) · Ministry of Defence · UK Health Security Agency (HIV↔health records) · Dept for Education · Homes England (30M records) · Competition & Markets Authority · Welsh Revenue Authority

**Local councils:** Lewisham (auto-enrolled 500+ families) · Leicestershire · Gateshead · Richmond · Wandsworth · Westmorland & Furness ("single view of the child") · London Office of Technology & Innovation (rough sleeping)

## OTHER GOVERNMENTS

Australia — Medicare+Centrelink+Tax

Germany — register census

United States — Defense Health Agency, 200M+ records

Canada — Ontario; Environment Canada

Chile — Health Ministry

Gambia — 2024 census

Laos — children's health records

## INTERNATIONAL ORGANISATIONS

European Union — Medicines Agency

United Nations — UNHCR (refugee data)

## UNIVERSITIES (RESEARCH)

Cambridge

Harvard / Vanderbilt

Stanford

Princeton / Berkeley — 108M people

Bern (Switzerland)

Splink is free and open-source, so there is **no registry of who uses it**. This is only the use that's been publicly documented — the real footprint is larger and untraceable.

## WHAT THEY DON'T TELL YOU · 3 / 4

### COUNTRIES THAT DON'T USE SPLINK — BUT LINK YOUR RECORDS ANYWAY (THEIR OWN SYSTEMS)

Poland — GUS register census

Israel — Ofek + HMO health records

Scotland / Wales — SAIL, PHS

New Zealand — IDI

Ireland — Protected Identifier Key

Splink is just the **visible** instance. Linking citizens' records is near-universal — most states just use their own tools.

### THIS IS BECOMING THE GLOBAL NORM

Wealthy nations' census — 2020

48 UNECE countries

Door-to-door 46%

Linked records 54%

Projected — 2030

~18%

Linked / register-based

The door-to-door census is being retired. The Nordics have linked everything for decades. OECD & the UN endorse it.

### FROM COUNTING → TO IDENTIFYING YOU (FUNCTION CREEP)

#### WAS

##### Count the population

Anonymous statistics for planning

#### NOW

##### Match you in real time, in court

Find your probation record as you appear

#### NEXT

##### Pull police arrest records

Look up your PNC number for arrest info

## THE GDPR PARADOX: THE PRIVACY LAW ALLOWS IT

### No consent needed

"Public task" is a lawful basis on its own (Art 6). Consent was never required.

### Statistics carve-out

Art 89 specifically permits linking for statistics, with light safeguards.

### They needn't tell you

Art 14(5)(b): skip notifying people if it's "disproportionate effort." The silence is legal.

### So the scandal isn't a crime — it's the rule itself

The world's strongest privacy law **authorises the very thing people think it protects them from**. Nobody broke GDPR. GDPR was written to permit it. "But it's compliant" becomes the indictment, not the defence.

## THE HONEST BOTTOM LINE

**It's real:** ~8 countries + EU + UN documented; the practice itself in ~26 of 48 wealthy nations.

**It's lawful:** statute, not consent — by design.

**It's growing:** heading toward near-universal by 2030.

**You weren't asked, told, and can't opt out.**

## WHERE THIS SHOULD GO

medConfidential

Foxglove (litigation)

Bureau of Investigative Journalism

Guardian data team

ICO

Office for Statistics Regulation

**The government is building a single picture of you from everything it holds — legal, global, and **you were never asked**.**

Sources: GOV.UK Algorithmic Transparency Records · ONS · Australian Bureau of Statistics · NHS England · Splink official documentation · UNECE 2020 census round · OECD/UN guidance. Two adversarially fact-checked research passes; 50 claims verified, 0 false. Full report & archived evidence: [brandonmyers.net/writing/the-quiet-joining-up](https://brandonmyers.net/writing/the-quiet-joining-up)